Builders OF THE FAITH

A powerful Swaminarayan sect is erecting some of the biggest and grandest Hindu edifices across cities in the world, the latest being the temple in Abu Dhabi. The inside story of how they are doing it

By **JUMANA SHAH**

The chanting of Sanskrit shlokas reverberated through the sand dunes on the outskirts of the city of Abu Dhabi on Basant Panchami. Pride welled in the eyes of the couple of thousand *Haribhakts* (volunteers) who had gathered from across the world for the past few months to prepare for the week-long inaugural celebrations of the biggest Hindu temple in the United Arab Emirates. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was part of the Lokarpan ceremony on February 14, after the Gujarat-based Swaminarayan sect's spiritual leader Mahant Swami did the *pran pratishtha*.

The temple has been built by BAPS (Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha), a Vaishnavite sect of Hinduism established in the early 1800s when Ghanshyam Pande, born into a Brahmin family in Ayodhya, emerged as a scholarly ascetic commanding a massive following through his travels and discourses. Pande became known as Sahajanand Swami and eventually as Lord Swaminarayan to his followers who believe he is an incarnation of Lord Krishna. Sahajanand Swami settled in Gujarat and during his lifetime created two dioceses—Vadtal Gadi (Kheda) and Ahmedabad Gadi. From these, four more sects have emerged—BAPS, Maninagar Gadi, Vasna Gadi and Sokhada Gadi. BAPS emerged from the Vadtal Gadi.

Established by Shastriji Maharaj in 1907, BAPS claims to have more than a million members across the world, 80,000 volunteers, a global network of over 1,550 mandirs, 5,025 centres and boasts of 17,000 weekly assemblies. Some of the popular BAPS temples are the Akshardhams in Robbinsville (New Jersey, US), New Delhi and Gandhinagar (Gujarat); and the mandirs in London, Houston, Chicago, Atlanta, Toronto, Los Angeles and Nairobi. BAPS spokesperson Bansal Bhalja says mandirs are coming up in Paris, Sydney and Johannesburg next. Land has also been offered by the king of Bahrain to construct a temple there.

BAPS has emerged as the most powerful of the six Swaminarayan sects, owing largely to its strong social bonding and the unstinted support for its community, combined with financial muscle and reckoning in the global power corridors. For several decades now, in Gujarat at least, politicians across party lines have sought the blessings of the local Swaminarayan sect. Though BAPS remains apolitical, its propensity to patronise 'suitable' candidates is an open secret.

The affluent Patidar community makes up the sect's largest chunk of followers, though it is not limited to them. A statement issued by the sect underlines that a Muslim king donated land for the Hindu mandir in Abu Dhabi, the lead architect is a Catholic Christian, the project manager was a Sikh, the foundation

₹700 CRORE
Cost of the BAPS mandir in Abu Dhabi

15,000 TONNES
Amount of pink sandstone from Rajasthan used for mandir exterior

6,000 TONNES
White Italian marble used for the interiors

30 THOUSAND+
No. of stone pieces carved by 5,000 skilled artisans in India